

Cybersecurity for SME Employees

Module 3.2 – Recognizing Phishing Attacks

1 Objective

Help employees identify and avoid phishing attempts across email, SMS, phone calls, and websites.

2 Introduction

Phishing is one of the most common and dangerous forms of social engineering. It tricks individuals into giving up personal information, clicking malicious links, or downloading malware. Every employee must learn how to recognize the signs and stay alert.

3 What is Phishing?

- Phishing is a method used by attackers to trick people into revealing confidential data or installing malware.
- Delivered through email (most common), but also via SMS, voice calls, or fake websites.
- Often impersonates banks, delivery services, government agencies, or company leadership.

4 Common Phishing Channels

- **Email (Phishing):** Fake invoices, fake password reset links, or fake IT support emails.
- **SMS (Smishing):** "Your package is delayed—click here to reschedule."
- **Phone (Vishing):** Callers pretending to be from IT, HR, or even law enforcement.
- **Websites:** Spoofed login pages that look like real company or banking portals.

5 Common Signs of Phishing Emails

- Urgent or threatening language ("Your account will be locked!").
- Requests for personal or company information.
- Misspellings, poor grammar, or awkward phrasing.
- Suspicious links or email addresses.

- Unexpected attachments or login prompts.

6 How to Analyze a Suspicious Email

- Hover over links to preview the URL without clicking.
- Check sender email for inconsistencies (e.g., `support@amaz0n.com`).
- Look for generic greetings like “Dear user” instead of your name.
- Don’t open attachments from unknown or untrusted senders.

7 Example Scenario

An email arrives from what looks like your HR department asking you to confirm your updated salary details via a link. The email is slightly off, but looks urgent. If you click the link, it takes you to a fake login page designed to steal your credentials.

8 Steps to Take If You Receive a Phishing Message

- Don’t reply, click any links, or download attachments.
- Report it immediately to your IT/security team.
- Delete the message once it has been reported.
- Warn colleagues if the email appears to target multiple people.

9 Conclusion

Phishing can happen to anyone, anywhere. Learning to spot warning signs is essential. Always think before you click, and when in doubt—report. Up next, we’ll explore advanced, more targeted phishing attacks like spear phishing and CEO fraud.